

Hazrat Esa ﷺ

The Qur'ān and Hazrat Esa ﷺ

In the same manner that Rasulullah ﷺ is the last of all the Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) so Nabi Esa ﷺ is the last of the Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) of Israel. Between the time of Nabi Esa ﷺ and the time of Nabi Muhammad ﷺ, no prophet appeared. This in between period was a time when Revelation was cut off. Nabi Esa ﷺ is considered the Renovator among the prophets of Israel because after the Divine Law of the Toraat, no more sacred scriptures appeared than the Injeel of Nabi Esa ﷺ which served as the guidance for Bani Israel. In fact the Injeel is looked upon as the completion of the Toraat.

Moreover Nabi Esa ﷺ was the greatest one to prophecy about the coming of our Nabi Muhammad ﷺ.

The Qur'ān has in various places described the history of Nabi Esa ﷺ in quite a bit of detail and by way of introduction to his life story has touched upon the story of his mother Hazrat Mariam, so that the Qur'ān's message of reminding of the "days of Allah" be completed. Nabi Esa ﷺ in the Qur'ān is sometimes called 'Esa'—Jesus. In some places he is called the *Maseeh* "the *Messiah*" and in some other places is referred to as '*Ibn Mariam*' the "Son of Mariam."

Imran and Hannah

In the story on Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام and Hazrat Yahya عليه السلام it was already mentioned that among Bani Israel there was a very pious man Imran because who of his piety and righteousness was made responsible for leading the prayers. His wife, Hannah, was also known for her extreme piety. This Imran had no children while his wife had a great desire for children. It is said that Hannah once saw a bird feeding its young ones. Seeing this the desire in her for children became so great that she lifted up her hands and prayed earnestly:

"O Lord grant me also children like this that they may become the light of my eyes and the happiness of my heart."

The *Du'a* which emanated from her heart was accepted and a few days later Hannah discovered that she was pregnant. The Qur'ān tells story:

"Behold a woman of Imran said: O My Lord, I do dedicate unto you what is in my womb For your special service. So accept this of me. For you hear and Know all things.

When she was delivered, she said: "O My Lord! I am delivered of a female child and Allah knows best what she brought forth. And no wise is the male like a female. I have named her Marry and I commend her and her offspring for your protection from the Evil One, the Rejected."

(3:35—36)

When this Mariam reached the age of discernment it was decided by an unanimous verdict that she be given into

the care of Hazrat Zakarya ﷺ who placed her in a special chamber near the place of worship for special worship by day. At night she used to retire to the home of her aunt Elisha where she spent the night.

The Piety of Hazrat Mariam

Hazrat Mariam used to busy herself with the worship of Allah night and day and when her time came for service to the Holy Temple she served well indeed. Soon she became known for her piety and abstinence from worldly pursuits, so much so that Allah through the Angels announced:

"(O Prophet), call to mind the time when the Angels declared: O Mariam Allah has chosen you and purified you and have chosen you above all the women of all nations.

O Mariam, worship your Lord devoutly, prostrate yourself and bow down in prayer with those who bow down." (3:42—43)

In the above verses, with regard to the virtues of Hazrat Mariam various points have come to the fore for example: Can a woman become a prophet? Was Hazrat Mariam a *Nabi*? If she was not a *Nabi*, then what is the meaning of these verses expanding her virtues?

Maulana Hifzur Rahman in discussing these questions in detail came to the following conclusions:

- (a) A woman cannot become a *Nabi*.
- (b) To call Hazrat Mariam a *Nabi* would be correct by the general meaning of the word.
- (c) Thus the meaning of the verses expanding his virtues becomes clear viz., that she has a rank above all the

women of the world. Her rank above other women who are not Nabies is because she is a *Nabi*. And her position above these who are not *Nabies* (e.g., Hawwa, Sara, Hajira etc.), is because of the Qur'ānic texts which expound her high position and rank. (*Note*: those who wish to see the details of this discussion may refer to the original book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy.)

Hazrat Maseeh

Among the high profile messengers whose advent was expected by the Jews according to the prophecies in their scriptures, the Masseh was one. Hazrat Yahya عليه السلام had already informed them that neither was he the Prophet Eliya عليه السلام, nor was himself 'that prophet' for whom they were waiting. And neither was he the Promised Messiah. In fact he was the caller towards the mission of the Messiah and bringing the good news of his coming. The Qur'ān also calls Hazrat Yahya عليه السلام and Hazrat Zakariya عليه السلام as the bringer of the good news of the Messiah as appears in *Surah Al-Baqarah* (2:39). The Qur'ān tells the story of the birth of Hazrat Esa عليه السلام in these terms:

"(Remember that time) when the Angels said:
O Mariam, Allah gives you glad tidings of a
word from Him, his name shall be Esa the son
of Mariam, held in honour in this world and
the Hereafter And of the company of those
nearest to Allah.

He shall speak to men in childhood and in
maturity

And he shall be (of the Company) of the
righteous.

She said: "O My Lord, how shall I have a son
when no man has touched me"?

He said: "Even so: Allah creates what he wills
And when he has decreed a plan he only says to
it:-

"Be and it is!"

And Allah will teach him the Book and wisdom
The Law and the gospel." (3:45-47)

"[And O Muhammad ﷺ] Remember Mariam in
the Book when she withdrew from her family
to a place in the East.

She placed a screen to screen herself from
them.

Then we sent to her our Angel and he appeared
before her

As a man in all aspects.

She said: "I seek refuge from you to Allah, Most
Gracious (come not near) if you do fear
Allah."

He said: "Nay, I am only a messenger from thy
Lord Allah

To announce to you the gift of a holy son."

She said: "How shall I have a son seeing that no
man has touched me

And I am not unchaste

He said: "So (it will be).

your Lord says: "That is easy for Me and we
wish to appoint him.

As a sign unto men and a mercy from us.

It is a matter so decreed." (21:16—19)

The Angel Jibrael reported the good news to her and blew into her breast and in this manner the word of Allah reached her. The Qur'ân tells the details in *Surah Ambiyaa*, *Surah Mariam* and *Surah Tahreem*:

"And Maryam the daughter of Imran who guarded her chastity

And we breathed into (her body) of our spirit.

And she testified to the truth of her Lord And his Revelations

And was one of the devout servants."

"And remember her who guarded her chastity.

We breathed into her of Our Spirit

And we made her and her son a sign for all peoples." (21:91)

Further:

"So she conceived him and she retired with him to a remote place.

And the pains of birth drove her to the trunk of a palm tree

She cried (in anguish):

"Ah would that I have died before this.

Would that I had been a thing forgotten and out of sight."

But a voice cried out to her from heneath the palm tree:

"Grieve not for your Lord has provided a rivulet beneath you.

And shake towards yourself the trunk of the
palm tree:

It will let full fresh ripe dates upon you."

So eat and drink and cool your eyes

And if you see any man, Say:

"I have vowed a fast to Allah, Most Gracious.

And this day will I not enter into talk with any
human being."

At length she brought the babe to her people,

Carrying him in her arms.

They said: "O Mariam, truly an amazing thing
have you brought.

O sister of Harun, your father was not a man of
evil

And neither was your mother a woman unchaste
(where from is this?)

But she pointed to the babe

They said: "How can we talk to one who is a
child in the cradle?"

He said: "I am indeed a servant of Allah

He has given me revelation and made me a
prophet."

And He has made me blessed wherever I be

And has enjoined upon me Prayer and charity
as long as I live.

He has made me kind to my mother

And not overbearing and miserable."

So peace is on me the day I was born, the day
that I die

I shall be raised up to life (again) (19:22—33)

Note: It is said that Haroon عليه السلام was a very pious and righteous man in the family of the Hazrat Mariam in previous years. He was very famous. (Ibn Katheer)

When the people heard such words of wisdom from the tongue of a suckling young babe, they were astonished and they realised that Mariam was cleared of all suspicious of immoral behaviour. They realized that her son was a 'sign' from Allah.

This news was not such a thing that could remain a secret. The strange happenings of his birth caused wonderment near and after. All places people were astonished at the events of Esa (*Alaihis Salām*)'s birth. From the very beginning people took up various position regarding the holy personality of Esa عليه السلام. The pious ones looked upon his coming as a sign of the coming of good fortune while those inclined towards evil looked upon it as a sign of bad luck and ill-fortune. And in this manner they became filled with hatred and jealousy. In such an opposing atmosphere Allah took charge of the bringing up of the young child and his protection, so that one day at his hands the dead hearts of Bani Israel could be granted new life, and so that their tree of spiritual development could bear fruit once again.

"And we made the son of Mariam and his mother
as a sign,

And we gave them both shatter on higher ground

Affording Rest and Security

And furnished with springs." (23:50)

The Qur'ān only mentions this one incident from the childhood of Esa عليه السلام. Apart from that the rest of his

childhood which has no bearing upon remind others and guiding them has been left aside.

Description of Esa ﷺ

According to the *Hadith* on the *Mi'raaj* of Rasulullah ﷺ he was reported to have said: "I met Esa ﷺ and I found him to be of moderate height, being reddish, white in colour. His body appeared so clean as if he had just stepped out of the bathroom after a shower. According to another report it is mentioned that his locks of hair used to hang onto his shoulders. Still other reports mention that his colour was that of wheat.

His Advent as a Messenger of Allah

The complete picture of the Jews and their beliefs and their practical lives is told in the Toraat. However the results of their actions is told in the Qur'ān in the following words:

"And we gave Musa ﷺ the Book and followed him up

With a succession of Messengers. And we gave the son of Mariam clear sings and strengthened him with the holy spirit.

Is it that whenever there comes to you an Apostle with what you yourselves desire not, you are puffed up with pride.

Some you called imposters and others you slay!"

They say: "Our hearts are the wrappings which (preserve gods word: We need no more)

Nay Allah's curse is on them for their blasphemy little is it that they believe." (2:87—88)

Allah says:

"And O Esa, behold I did restrain the children of Israel from violence to you. When you did show them clear signs And the unbelievers among them said:

"This is nothing but evident magic." (5:112)

('And I have come to you) to attest the Law which was before me.

And to make lawful to you part of what was before forbidden to you

I have come to you with a clear sign from your Lord.

So fear Allah and obey me.

It is Allah who is my Lord and your Lord.

Then worship Him. This is way that is straight."

When Esa found unbelief on their part, he said:

"Who will be my helpers to the work of Allah?

Said the disciples: "We are Allah's helpers

We believe in Allah and do you bear witness that we are Muslims." (3:50—52)

Allah also says:

"The in their wake (Nooh ﷺ and Ibraheem ﷺ) we followed them up with others of our Messengers, we sent after them Esa ﷺ the son of Mariam and bestowed on him the Injeel. And we ordained in the hearts of those who followed him Compassion and mercy.

Also:

"Remember the day) when Allah will say:

O Esa, son of Mariam, recount My favour of you and your mother

Behold, I strengthened you with the Holy Spirit
So that you spoke to the people in childhood
and maturity

Behold I taught you the Book and wisdom, the
Torah and the Injeel." (5:110)

And:

"And remember Esa ﷺ, the son of Mariam said:

"O Children of Israel I am the Messenger of Allah sent to you confirming the law which came before me and giving glad tidings of a messenger to come after me above name shall be Ahmad....." (61:6)

The Clear Signs (Miracles)

It has already been discussed that in accepting the truth and reality man's nature has always been of two kinds: Firstly there has been this that the claimant to truth should prove the truth of his claims by bringing forth solid arguments and proofs to substantiated his claims.

Secondly there has been the system where together with such arguments and proofs, there should be from Allah's side assistance for the truth by such happenings which are against the natural laws of nature and before which man is completely helpless and unable to emulate.

This second way creates within the reason and thoughts of man such a reaction that he is forced to admit that this happening taking place at the hands of the claimant to truth

i.e. the prophet or messenger, is not his own action but is actually the act of the Power of Allah. This is actually a further proof of the truth brought by the Messenger as the Qur'ān states:

"When you threw (a handful of sand) it was not your act but Allah's." (8:17)

In this verse this fact is mentioned. But of the two ways mentioned above the more effective one is the former in the eyes of those who have a high place in knowledge and rational thought and they are more inclined to accept the truth of the prophet coming with such proofs and arguments and accept his call towards *Imān*. On the other hand the people with power and high positions and those under their influence of the general public are more impressed with the second way in which works of miracles are involved. They look upon such acts as being out of this world and a sign from God.

In short, in the Book of Allah and its sentences these *A'ayaat* (signs) are mentioned so many times that hardly a *Surah* is found where in some way or other it is not mentioned.

Similarly the term '*Aayaat Bayyinaat*'—clear signs or verses has been mentioned very often concerning the Books of Allah (the Qur'ān, Taurait, Zaboor and Injeel) but some places it also refers to miracles.'

The Reality of a Miracle

The purpose of the mission of a prophet and a messenger is to bring guidance to the world and to teach mankind the path of religion. The Prophet by means of Revelation received from Allah delivers this task and shows the path towards truth by bringing forth arguments and proofs. He does not make the claim that nature and control of the

Celestial spheres are under his control but, in fact, repeatedly announces that he is a mere bringer of glad tidings and warnings from Allah's side, coming to call mankind towards Allah. He says clearly: "I am a human being and an ambassador of Allah. Nothing more." Thus it seems only natural that his claim towards the truth should be examined and so also his knowledge, his upbringing and his personality. But it is quite illogical that demands should be made of him to produce miracles, unnatural occurrences and to make extravagant interally impossible demands of him. It will be almost like demanding from a skilled physician to prove his skill in the medical field that he should with a magicians knock produce a smart book case or a wooden toy. This seems foolish because the physician never made the claim that he is a smart iron-smith or a black smith. His claim is only to provide healing for the sick for their bodily ills. Similarly the prophets of Allah do not make the claims that they have the power to control and manage the world. They only claim that they are the doctors of the spiritual illnesses of man.

However it has been the *Sunnat* of Allah that when for the guidance of any person or for the well-fare of all humanity a prophet has been sent, such a prophet has always been endowed with solid arguments and proofs and miracles. On the one side with the aid of Revelation from Allah comes forth with commands and prohibitions regarding the life on earth and pertaining to the life hereafter, producing a beautiful system of laws. On the other hand he also comes forth with some Divine Signs, to show the people to prove his coming from Allah side according to the needs of the hour and expedience. Moreover every prophet has been given these special signs (miracles) which according to the era in which he lives. According to the intellectual progress of the time and the special features of that nation and the country these miracles are shown in such a manner that the people of the

time are unable to imitate or emulate. If at such a time obstinacy and prejudice do not interfere, then because of being acquainted with their own arts and specialities, these people would be forced to admit that whatever they see happening in front of them of miracles is not of the handiwork of man, and could only be forthcoming from Allah.

For example, during the era of Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام there was a lot of interest in Astronomy and Chemistry. Then also the people used to associate the movement of the heavenly bodies with their own conditions and used to consider the heavenly bodies as having an influence on their lives. Hence they even went so far as to worship those bodies instead of worshipping Allah. The biggest of these heavenly bodies was the sun because it produced both light and heat, both of which were looked upon as being of the utmost importance for the continued life of the world and its existence. Hence they considered the fire to be the manifestation of the sun and worshipped fire. Moreover they were also quite aware of the special qualities of things and their effects and were also quite aware of the chemical composition of various elements of nature.

For the reason Allah sent Nabi Ibraheem عليه السلام for the guidance of his people and to call them to the worship of God and gave him such clear arguments and proofs with which to prove the wrong of their beliefs and to call them away from the adoration of external features and to remove the custom of ignorance from their beliefs.

Qur'ān states:

"That two the reasoning about us which we gave to Ibraheem عليه السلام (to use) against his people. We raise when we will degree after degree. For your Lord is full of wisdom and knowledge." (6:83)

On the other hand when the star-worshipping king and the people were beaten by Ibraheem (*Alaihis Salām*)'s arguments and proofs, decided to cast him into flaming fire the Creator, whose service Ibraheem ﷺ had rendered just said to the fire:

"O Fire, be cool and means of safety for
Abraheem...." (21:69)

In this manner Allah showed His power by bringing about this miracle which caused a tremendous upheaval in the court of the polytheists, which made the whole crowd unable to respond to it, causing them to remain beaten, defeated and humiliated.

"Then they sought a stratagem against him but
we made them to ones who lost most." (21-70)

Another example is this that in the era of Nabi Musa ﷺ the art of magic was a very important art which had an important position in Egyptian society. The Egyptians were skilled Magicians and well versed in this art. For this reason Nabi Musa ﷺ was granted the Toraat and with it also the 'shining hand' and 'the staff which turned into a snake.' When Nabi Musa ﷺ in combat with the Egyptian magicians exhibited the miracles which Allah had granted him, the magician on seeing these 'signs from Allah' exclaimed "This is not magic or sorcery. This is something apart from sorcery. This is something beyond the ability of man."

This was something which the true God has exhibited for the support of his true Messenger at the hands of that messenger. Those sorcerers were fully aware of the reality of magic. They then fearlessly declared in front of Firawn that from that day onwards they believed in the God of Musa ﷺ and Haroon ﷺ.

"So the magicians were thrown down to prostration

They said: We believe in the Lord of Haroon and Musa." (20:70)

"Fir'own said to the chiefs around him: This is indeed a sorceor well-versed: (26:34)

"When Musa ﷺ came to them with our clear signs, they said: "This is nothing but sorcery, faked up, never did we hear the like among our fathers of old." (28:36)

Hazrat Esa ﷺ and his Miracles

Similarly in the time of Nabi Esa ﷺ there was great interest and emphasis on medical science and on physics. People were greatly influenced by the Greek expertise in these sciences and for many decades the doctors and philosophers of Greece were exhibiting their expertise in these fields, impressing all towns and lands. But at the same time the people were far removed from the belief in the oneness of god and the correct teaching of the true religion. And so also was Bani Israel gone astray from the true path of faith although they were the people who prided themselves as being of the same off-spring as the prophets of old.

And so when according to Allah's *Sunnah* Nabi Esa ﷺ who chosen to be sent to mankind for their guidance, on the one side he was granted the Injeel (Bible) as his proof and argument and on the other side according to the needs of the time he was also granted a few miracles which were to have such an effect and influence upon the experts of that era that they on seeing these miracles being performed would be forced to admit that such an art could not be learnt or acquired but was from Allah for the support and strengthening of the Messenger of Allah.

Of the miracles Esa ؑ performed there are four which the Qur'ān clearly mentions:

- (a) Through the command of Allah he revived the dead back to life
- (b) Through the command of Allah he gave eye-sight to the blind and healed lepers from leprosy.
- (c) He used to make the form of a bird from clay and blew into it to bring it to life through Allah's command.
- (d) He used to tell people what they had eaten and what they had spent and what they had stored up in their houses.

Among all peoples there exists such healers, at whose hands and through whose efforts people who have reached the end of their hope for cure from some diseases a cure for their ills. And so also there was no shortage of such men of philosophy and physics who were experts on the relationship between body and soul. But when Nabi Esa ؑ without any such means started to exhibit these miracles without any means it had a different effect upon various peoples according to their faith and lack of faith. Those who were searches after truth, admitted that those acts were outside the powers of the ordinary man but were in fact a gift to the Nabi from Allah in order to support him and as a proof of him being an emissary from Allah. Those, in whose hearts were arrogance, hatred and jealousy, their prejudice allowed them to exclaim that:

"This is but open sorcery."

(37:15)

The *Mufasssireen* of the Qur'ān explain to us regarding the four miracles mentioned above that when the opponents of Nabi Esa ؑ rejected him and his call towards guidance and declared his miracles to be sorcery, then by way of

mocking him they used to say: "If you are really the Messenger of Allah, then tell us what we have eaten today and what have we left behind." Thereupon Esa ﷺ answered them seriously telling them what they ate and what was kept in their homes.

The manner in which the Qur'ān mentions this last miraculous deed and if one ponders over it one comes to know that there is another more deeper meaning in it. That is that Nabi Esa ﷺ spent much time and effort in advising his people to shun worldly possessions and live an ascetic life-style without love for this world. These who accepted his message used to follow this advice while others on the other side used to pretend to do so and hypocritically used to gather and store worldly goods. By means of this miracle he was able to uncover this hypocrisy on their part.

Apart from these four miracles, the fact that Nabi Esa ﷺ himself was born without a father was in itself a great sign and miracles from Allah as has already been explained. However whatever miracles took place at his hands and his immaculate birth was rejected and denied by the Jews out of jealousy. But even today some scientifically minded persons in Islam also deny these things. Some of them do so not of their own accord but after having come under the influence of European athersto and so that they may not be accused of being religiously influenced and prejudiced. Similarly as far as the giving of life to the dead they contend that before *Qiyamat* Allah will not give life to any dead ones. However the truth of giving life to the dead is no new thing because there were many occasions in the texts where Allah indeed gave life to the dead. (See 2:73, 259 and 260) In all these verses there is a clear mention of giving life to the dead on various occasions. And so also there are those who deny. Esa ﷺ being born without a father and they have spent much

energy to deny this in their writings. However in spite of the various views on this issue if one looks at all the textual evidences in the Qur'ān in an impartial way one comes to the conclusion that apart from the over zealous attitudes and excesses of the Christians and the attitude of deficiency of the Jews, the Qur'ān wants to stress the story of the immaculate birth of Jesus. The Jews and the Christians chose two apposite viewpoints on this issue.

On the one side the Jews considered him a fraud and a liar and the fabricator of a lie while the Christians went to the other extreme and called him a God and the son of God, the 3rd person in the trinity. In this regard the Qur'ān wants to show that the best way is the middle one and to put forth the correct belief in Esa ﷺ.

That is that Esa (Jesus) is not a false prophet, nor a liar and a fraud but is Allah's true prophet and messenger, calling people to the path of true guidance. Whatever he has shown of wonder works were not deeds of sorcery but miracles which Allah had worked. His birth was without a father but that does not necessarily make him a God. How can that person be a God who is in need of being born and for his birth is in need of a mother or a father and of all the needs of human beings. Such a person can never be God.'

In the Qur'ān an effort is made to disprove and condemn the false beliefs the Jews and Christians hold regarding Jesus. If it had been so that Jesus had been born of a father the Qur'ān would have stressed it from the very beginning as this is the main reason for him being considered a Divine personality. It would have been logical and expected that this belief should have been rejected from the beginning and a statement would have been made that so-and-so is the father of Jesus. This would have stopped the spread of the idea of

Divinity of Jesus in its tracks. In stead the Qur'ān goes on to state that even his virgin birth and birth without a father is no proof of any Divinity because:

"Verily the similitude of Jesus before Allah is as that of Adam عليه السلام. He created him from dust, then said to him: "Be and he was." (3:59)

Therefore if being born without a father qualifies him for divinity, then Adam who is born without father and mother, is more qualified for divinity."

Any those persons who have given other wrong interpretations and meanings of certain verses separately in order to reject the idea of Jesus being born without a father, they are all wrong because if all those verses are taken together then no other truth comes out of them except that Jesus was born without a father.

And as far as the rational reasoning and logic of this question is concerned, reason too does not consider it impossible to be born without a father. In fact in this modern age instances have come to the fore where birth takes place in ways apart from the generally accepted manner. And those ways of birth cannot be said to be against the laws of nature because up to now we have not acquired the full knowledge of all the laws of nature. The more man progresses in the field of knowledge, so more and more new aspects of the laws of nature become known to him.

Hence very often the very thing which was considered impossible yesterday has suddenly become quite possible today.

Now let us listen to those miraculous deeds and find out what was Allah's aim in granting Esa عليه السلام these 'signs'.

Allay says:

"And Allah will teach him the Book and wisdom, the law and the Injeel. And appoint him a messenger to the children of Israel (with the message) "I have come to you with a sign from your Lord in that I make for you out of clay, as it were, the figure of a bird and breathe into it and it becomes a bird by Allah's leave.

And I heal those born blind and the lepers and I revive the dead by Allah's permission and I declare to you what you eat and what you store in your houses. Surely therein is a sign for you if you did believe.

"I have come to you to attest the Torah which was before me,

And to make lawful to you part of what was (before) forbidden to you;

I have come to you with a sign from your Lord.
So fear Allah and obey me.

It is Allah who is my Lord and your Lord.

Then worship Him. This is the way that is straight. (3:48—50)

(O Esa bin Mariam) Remember my favour of you) when you make out of clay (as it were) the figure of a bird,

By My leave, you breathe into it and it becomes a bird by My leave, And you heal those born blind and the lepers by My leave.

And behold you bring forth the dead by My leave." (5:110)

"But when he (Esa ﷺ) came to them with clear sings they said: "This is evident sorcery." (61:6)

Whenever the Apostle of Allah exhibited Allah's signs before their peoples, the rejectors always exclaimed that this was "clear sorcery or magic."

Esa ﷺ and His Teachings

Nabi Esa ﷺ at all during his mission endeavoured to call Bani Israel towards the path of truth and the true religion. This was done by putting before them various arguments aided also by miracles.

He taught them faith in the Oneness of Allah, to belief in the Messengers of Allah, to believe in the life of the Hereafter, and in the Angels of Allah, and in the predestination of good and evil by Allah, as well as in the Holy Books of the Messengers of Allah. Further he also called them towards good character and good manners and to avoid all bad characteristics, to be inclined towards the worship of Allah. He also advocated becoming involved with worldly pursuits and to detest the worldly things and to have love for the creation of Allah. These were the things toward which he called and made the object of his preaching.

His efforts were to teach Bani Israel the Torah, the Injeel and with good advices called towards these things. However, the Jews, through their hereditary crookedness as a result of centuries of disobedience and their rebellion against the commandments of Allah had become so courageous in their disobedience and their killing of various prophets had made their hearts become so hard, that except for a very small group of true ones, the majority of them had become so opposed to him that jealousy and hatred

had become their special characteristic. The result was that these who accepted the truth were mostly the poor and weak ones. These were looked down upon by the affluent and arrogant ones:

Allah says:

"When Esa ﷺ came with clear signs he said: "Now have I come to you with wisdom and in order to make clear to you some of the (points) on which you dispute, therefore fear Allah and obey me."

For Allah, He is my Lord and your Lord, so worship Him this is the straight way."

But sects from among themselves fell into disagreement

Then woe to the wrong doers the penalty of a generous day." (43:63—65)

Also: "And remember Esa ﷺ the son of Mariam said:

"O Children of Israel I am a Messenger of Allah to you, confirming the Torah which came before me and giving glad tidings of an Apostle to come after me, whose name shall be Ahmad. But when he came to them with clear signs, they said: "This is evident sorcery." (61:6)

And : "When Esa ﷺ found unbelief on their part he said: "Who will be my helpers to the work of Allah? "Said the disciples: "We are Allah's helpers: We believe in Allah And do bear witness. We are Muslims."

"Our Lord we believe in what you have revealed.

And we follow the Messenger, then write us down

Among those who bear witness." (3:52—53)

The Disciples of Nabi Esa ﷺ

In spite of the actions of his opponents and their nonseasonal talks Nabi Esa ﷺ continued to propagate the message of truth, spending night and day in calling them to the *Deen* with his solid arguments and clear signs. Through the Grace of Allah a few such sincere souls came forth who not only accepted faith in Allah but were greatly blessed with his companionship and were prepared to sacrifice their everything in for the spread of the truth, offering their very lives and their possessions in this effort. They used to spend most of their time in his holy company and became known as his disciples (companions) and the *Ansaarullah*, "the helpers of Allah."

They made the person of Esa ﷺ their exemplary model and in the most serious and dangerous situations never left his side.

The Qur'ān states:

"And behold, I inspired the disciples to have faith in me and My Messenger, they said: "We have faith and (O Allah) bear witness that we bow to Allah as Muslims." (5:114)

Further:

"O you who believe, be helpers of Allah as Esa ﷺ the son of Mariam said to the disciples: "Who will be my helpers (to the work) of Allah Said the disciples: "We are Allah's helpers!"

Then a portion of the children of Israel believed
and a portion disbelieved

But we gave power to those who believed
against their enemies

And they became the ones who prevailed."

(61:14)

It has already been mentioned that these disciples were from the poor and labourer community. This is so because has become Allah's *Sunnat* that those who answer the call of the prophets are generally from these poor people. These are the ones showing the spirit of sacrifice. Generally it is the ones with high positions who because of their arrogance and pride become the opponents of the prophets and become the stumbling stones in the way of success and progress. But when Allah's law of Retribution comes into operation, it is those wealth and poor ones who are successful while the arrogant ones are either destroyed or defeated.

Comparrision Regarding Disciples

The Qur'ān describes the virtues of the disciples. We have the contents of the verses of *Surah Al-Imran* in front of us. When Hazrat Esa ﷺ called for helpers on the path of Allah, they were the first group to answer to his call saying: "We are the helpers of Allah: When in *Surah Saff* Allah called the believers to become helpers of Allah, the Qur'ān gave these pious ones as an example of helpers of Allah, and with their example encouraged others to follow suit. In *Surah Maida* such a picture was given of their acceptance of truth and faith and their submission to the message of truth which porrays their sincerity, and search after truth. All that tells of the ear which portrays their sincerity, and search after truth. All that tells of the era when Esa ﷺ was

present among them but after his being 'lifted up' to the heavens, they delivered such great service that the Qur'ān states:

"That we supported those with Imran against their enemies and they prevailed." (61:14)

Shah Abdul Aziz in his *Tafseer* on this verse gave the following verdict:

"After Nabi Esa عليه السلام, his disciples made great efforts and then their *Deen* was spread. These disciples who are praised so grandly in the Bible, the Bible also depicts them all as having been cowards in that at the time of need they all left the side of Esa عليه السلام when their support was of a great need at a time when he was surrounded by his enemies.

The Qur'ān on the other hand points a different picture. In *Surah Al-Imran* it states that at the time of danger, when Esa عليه السلام called upon his disciples towards helping the *Deen* they all answered with bravery and courage: "We are the helpers of Allah!" Then they exhibited their bravery with sincerity and faith and showed that help. And in *Surah Saff* it says that whatever they had promised Esa عليه السلام was said in his presence and they carried out that promise with complete sincerity one faithfulness, proving themselves to be true believers. That is why Allah helped them and made them victorious over enemies.

Looking at this comparison between the Qur'ān and the Bible any honest judge will come to the conclusion that the truth lies with the Qur'ān and it seems that scholars of the Bible had brought about changes in its texts.

It seems clear that such incidents have been included in the story so that the story of the crucifixion could seem to be true when he was supposed to have exclaimed on the cross.

"My God, My God, why has thou forsaken me?" Apparently at that time no one stood by him. In any case these events as given in the Bible are fabricated and are of no truth and consequence.

The Descent of the Table from Heaven

The Holy Qur'ān tells the story of the descent of the table from heaven in its inimitable way:

"Behold the disciples said: O Esa ﷺ son of Mariam can your Lord send down to us a table set (with viands) from heaven.

He, Esa ﷺ, said: "Fear Allah if you have faith."

They said: "We only wish to eat thereof and satisfy our hearts

And to know that you have told the truth and that we ourselves

May be witnesses to the miracle."

Said Esa ﷺ, the son of Mariam:

"O Allah, our Lord send us from heaven a table set (with viands) that there may be for us, for the first and the last of us, a solemn festival and a sign from you, And provide for us sustenance for you are the best sustainer."

Allah said: "I will send it down unto you.

But if any of you after that resists faith, I will punish him with a penalty such as I have not afflicted on any one among all the peoples."

Now did this table descend from heaven? or not? The Qur'ān does not give any detail and neither is there any confirmation in any authentic *Hadith*. However in the sayings of the *Sahabah* and *Tabi'een* we find some details.

Mujahid and Hasan al-Basri state that table did not descend. They state that the condition on which the table was to descend was such that the Questions realized that man is a weak beings with many weaknesses. It should not be such that because of a simple mistake or untoward act they should be punished with such a painful punishment. Hence they withdrew their request.

Moreover if the table had descended the Christians would have rejoiced in tremendous fashion and the event would have become so well-known all over. This is also the reason why in Christian literature there is no mention of the event at all.

Hazrat Abdullah bin Abbaas رضي الله عنه and Ammaar bin Yaasir رضي الله عنه are of the opinion that the table did descend. The majority of scholars hold this opinion. However with regard to the descend of this table there are various contrasting views. On this *Mas'ala* Shah Abdul Qadir agrees with Mujahid and Hasan al-Basari and in this connection he mentions other interesting point:

In this regard Hazrat Ammar bin Yaasri رضي الله عنه said something of great warning:

"The people of Esa عليه السلام asked him to let Allah sent down a table from the heavens and Allah replied that He accepts their request on condition that they would not commit deceit thereafter and not keep it a hidden secret and that they would not make it a means of gathering treasures. Otherwise it will be ended and they would be punished with a painful punishment as has not been given to anyone else before them."

O You Arabs! think about your own condition! You used to hold onto the tails of your camels and goats as you herded them in the deserts. Then Allah out of His Mercy sent amongst you His chosen Messenger whose character and family you knew quite well. He gave you these glad tidings that very soon you will conquer foreign nations and lands and be victorious over them He prohibited you most strongly from looking at the shine and splendour of wealth and not to treasure up gold and silver and by Allah he warned you that not many nights and days will pass before you will hoard up treasures of gold and silver through that you will become worthy of Allah's painful punishment."

(Tafseer Ibn Katheer Vol. II Surah Maidah)

Esa (Alaihis Salām)'s Ascent into the Heavens

Nabi Esa ﷺ never married and never built a house in which to live. He used to travel from town to town, village to village preaching the word of Allah and whenever the night came over him, he used to spend the night without homely comforts. Because his person was a means to people acquiring physical as well as spiritual healing, wherever he went the people gathered around him with great devotion and enthusiasm, prepared to sacrifice for his sake.

The Jews looked upon his extreme popularity with the masses and became filled with jealousy and envy, looking upon all this as a sign of danger for them. They could not tolerate this in their hearts. At that time the Jews according to the prophecies of their scriptures were expecting two

Messiahs—one, the Messiah bringing guidance and two' a messiah of falsehood.

It is most unfortunate that when the 'messiah of Guidance' appeared, they looked upon him as the 'Messiah of falsehood'. Their leaders and learned scholars, the pharisees and the sadducees started to make evil plans against the holy person of Esa ﷺ. They decided that for them to be successful, there was no other way out then to have him crucified at the hands of the King of the time.

For the last couple of centuries the Government of Judea was supposed to be in the hands of the herodus, but actually only about a quarter of the century fell under him. The actual rule over the land was in the hands of the Roman emperor who was a clear polytheist and on his behalf the governor of Judea was pilatus.

The Jews were resentful of this polytheist governor whose governorship they considered as a curse upon them. Yet the Jealousy burning in their hearts against Nabi Esa ﷺ, topped with their inferiority complex join out of being for centuries practically slaves have made them blind to truth that without considering the consequences of their deeds they proceeded to the door of Pilatus to solicit his aid in their fight of Jealousy against Nabi Esa ﷺ, giving the complaint:

"Sir, this man is not only a danger to us but also to the government. If an effort is not made against him now, neither will our *Deen* be safe, nor will your government remain safe in your hands. For this man has shown such feats which made the people incline towards him. He is all the time involved with these things that he is trying with the might of the people to defeat

you and make himself king of Bani Israel." Not only has he mislead the people in their worldly affairs, but he has even set about changing our religion and is busy making our people irreligious. It is very necessary that this corruption should be stopped so that this evil be stopped at its early stages."

After quite a bit of conversation pilatus gave them permission to arrest Esa ﷺ and to bring him before the governor like a common criminal. When the leaders of Bani Israel acquired this permission, they were very pleased. They congratulated each other that their plot was finally successful. They then decided to await the right moment for his arrest so that among the common people a minimum of unrest would result.

(New Testament John, Chapter II v 47 + 51. St. Mark, Vol. 1-2, Chapter 13)

When Nabi Esa ﷺ perceived the disbelief, rejection and enmity of the Jews, he called his disciples together and told them: "The enmity of the leaders and priests of Bani Israel is not hidden to you. The seriousness of the situation and the great trial ahead of us demands that I should ask you this question: Who of you are prepared in the face of this unbelief and rejection to be prepared to stand up bravely and with courage and be helpers of Allah?" On hearing this question from Nabi Esa ﷺ, all of them answered with great enthusiasm and true *Imān*: "We are helpers of Allah and worship Him. Be witness that we are Muslims and faithful." They then made *Du'a* to Allah: "O Lord, We have brought faith in your Revealed Book and are true followers of your messenger. Write down our names as being among those devoted to truth."

With regard to the opposition of the Jews towards the missionary activities of Nabi Esa ﷺ there seems no difference in the stories told by the Qur'ān and the Bible, but regarding what happened after that, there are two completely different stories with regard to the events. There is such a difference in the stories that it seems there is no way of reconciling the two versions. However both the Jews and Christians more or less agree with what happened. The main difference is that the Jews took pride in what they were supposed to have done, while the Christian look upon the actions of the Jews as a clear sign of the cause of God being upon them.

The Jewish and Christian versions state that the leaders of the Jews came to know that Nabi Esa ﷺ and his disciple were hidden in a certain house and they saw it to be a golden opportunity not to be missed. They surrounded the place and arrested Esa ﷺ. From there in a very humiliating way they took him to the court of Pilatus that he may have him crucified. Pilatus did not consider Esa ﷺ to be guilty of a crime and wanted to set him free. However at the insistence of the Jews he handed him over to the Roman soldiers, who put a crown of thorns on his head, spit on him and striking him on his body and after various insults and humiliations hang him on a cross like a common criminal. Then they struck nails through both his hands on the cross and lastly struck him with a small spear on his breast which opened up the breast. Thereafter he passed away on the cross exclaiming: "My God, My God why has thou forsaken me?"

Practically the same story is told in all the other three books of the New Testament Bible. After reading this supposed version one is struck by the fact that according to this version, Esa's ﷺ death took place with him in a helpless and friendless situation and in a very painful manner. It is

true that many of Allah's holy and pious persons had to face these kinds of trials but it seems as if this very story is a clear indication of it being a fabricated story and a forgery. The story shows that Nabi Esa ﷺ did not face the events like a resolute prophet or a righteous person with courage, but died with a voice complaining about God having forsaken him: "My God My God why hast thou forsaken me?" This is some kind of complaint at a time of helplessness which is not expected of the prophets. Moreover, according to the same Injeel Nabi Esa ﷺ is supposed to have on three occasions prayed to Allah: 'O My father, if at all possible word off from me this cup of 'death.'

And when this request was not granted he, in disappointed said: "If there is no other way out for me but to drink the cup of death, then let thy will come to pass."

What is surprising is this that if in accordance with the belief in the doctrine atonement, it has already been decided by God and His Son, then what is the meaning of this request above? And if those utterances of his was as a result of his human weakness and natural qualities, then still after having come to know the verdict of Allah why should he complain of being forsaken as he gave up the ghost and died? Fact of the matter is this that the Christians accepted the fabricated story as told by the Jews, who in arrogance and were exceedingly happy at the events. They used to say that if he was the real Messiah, Allah would not have delivered him into their hands that he had to complain to God up to his death. He was waiting for God to save him but God did nothing to do so. The Jews used to say: "Our forefathers at the time used to challenge that if he was really the son of God and the Promised Messiah why did God not save him from humiliation and insults and from our hands?"

The facts are that when the Christians could not find and answer to these taunts and there remained no solid ground for the belief in the doctrine of atonement, they added another fabricated chapter to the story. In the Book of St. John we read:

"But when he came to Esa ~~see~~ he saw that he had died and he did not break his bones. But one of the soldiers with a small spear pieced his ribs and immediately blood and water flowed out of the wound. Thereafter, Joseph of Armelita, a disciple of Jesus in fear of the Jews went to Pilatus secretly, seeking permission to take hold of the corpse of Jesus. Pilatus gave permission and he came along and took the body of Jesus. Nicodemus who had gone to Jesus the night before also came along with also five seen of mixed Mur. He took the body of Jesus and dressed the body in fragrant smelling things with cloth. As is the Jewish custom at the time of burial.

Near where they crucified him was a garden wherein there was a grave wherein up to then none had been buried. He placed the body of Jesus in this spot awaiting the Jewish day of preparation. On the Saturday Mary Maqdalene came to the grave at a time when it was still dark. She found the stone which covered the grave had been moved away and ran towards Simon Peter and the other disciples whom Jesus used to love and told them that Jesus had been taken from his grave and that she did now know where he has been placed.

However Mary was standing outside the grave, crying and when she bent down to look inside the grave, she saw two angels dressed in white one sitting at the head side and the other sitting at the foot end where the body of Jesus had been laid down. They said to her: 'O Woman, why do you cry?

She replied: "I cry because My God has been taken away and I do not know where he has been taken."

Saying this, she moved back and saw Jesus standing and failed to recognise him. Jesus said to her: "Mary!"

She turned around and in the Hebrew tongue replied: "*Rabboni*." (O Master).

Jesus told her: "Do not touch me," for I have not yet ascended to my father. Go to my brothers and tell them: I assumed unto my father and your father, my God and your God.

Mary Magdalene went to the disciples and gave them the message: 'I have seen God and He told me these things.'

Then on that day, the first of the week, at evening time when the door leading to where the disciples were, was closed, for fear of the Jews, Jesus came and stood in their midst and said: "May you all be safe."

Saying this he showed them his hands and his ribs and when the disciples saw this they were pleased. He again said to them:

"May you be safe."

"Just as the father sent me, so I send you."

Saying this he blew at them and said to them:

"Receive the Holy Ghost."

(John Chapter 19, V. 33, 34, 38 till 44 and Chapter 20, V. 1-22)

Every person after only a little thought will realize that this chapter is completely disjointed from the previous story. In fact it becomes exceedingly difficult to understand that these two incidents pertain to the same person. The first story speaks of a person who is helpless, disappointed and complains of having been forsaken, whereas the person in the last story is one who is endowed with godly qualities, is one near to Allah and is completely at ease with whatever befalls him and

is in fact hopeful of what happens, considering it an important part of his mission and duty.

In any case the truth is something else and it was a long time after this that the Christian invented the doctrine of announcement and in that respect they fabricated this forged story. For this reason the Qur'ān set about to remove the curtain of ignorance and darkness from this story and to enlighten on the right path:

The Qur'ān states that at the time when Bani Israel made plans and plotted against Esa عليه السلام in their secret plots at that same time Allah predestined that no power on earth, no matter how strong and mighty, will be able to harm Esa عليه السلام or have a victory over him and Allah had resolved that His protection will preserve him against all plots. The result was that when Bani Israel surrounded him, they failed to do him any harm. He was lifted up from this earth into the heavens and when Bani Israel entered the house, the situation became confused and dubious to them and greatly disappointed they failed in their attempt to arrest him. In the manner Allah fulfilled his promise which He gave Esa عليه السلام and his mother about saving them. The details of the above is this: When Nabi Esa عليه السلام realized that the rejection and disbelief of Bani Israel had reached such a stage that they were prepared to resort to violence to acquire their aims against him, he gathered his disciples in a certain house, and told them of the situation. He then told them: "The time for the major trial has come. This is the time of the test the effort to extinguishes the truth is at its height. Now I shall not remain among you much longer. Hence from now onwards it shall be your duty to remain steadfast on, the true religion, and to propagate and spread it will be your duty after me. Now tell me: Who will be Allah's true helpers?"

The disciples replied:

"We all will be Allah's faithful helpers. With our hearts we have believed in Allah and you are our witness to the truth of our faith."

After saying this, they prayed to Allah:

"O Allah, whatever we have uttered grant us steadfastness to remain on it. And write us down as being among those who help your *Deen*."

After this Nabi Esa ﷺ waited to see what direction the activities of his enemies would take and what Allah's decision was going to be in reply.

Allah in the Qur'ān related that when the Jews plotted against Esa ﷺ in secret, He also plotted against them that their plot would not be successful. And clearly in such a case against His secret plot none can be successful.

Qur'ān states:

"And the unbelievers plotted and planned and Allah too planned. And the best of planners is Allah."

(3:54)

According to the Arabic language, the word '*Mak'r*' (plotted) is used and it means to 'plan secretly'. According to laws of eloquence, when a person in defence also secretly plans, then no matter how good his action is in terms of ethics and religion, it is also called '*Maka'r*'— 'plotted with an aim to deceive' In most languages we have this saying: "the retaliation of evil is evil," even though every just-minded person will realize that the retaliation for evil is not really evil but can be good if done in defence. Here in the above verse the word '*Maka'r*' has been used for both the actions

of the enemies of Esa ﷺ as well as for the retaliation by Allah. This is a sign of the eloquence of the Qur'ān.

The fact is that there was a secret plotting to deceive on both sides. On the one side was the plan of the Almighty Allah and on the other side was the plan of the enemies who aimed to deceive.

Finally it came to the moment where the leaders of Bani Israel and the priest surrounded the house wherein Esa ﷺ was. The question arises is to what is the way under such circumstances whereby the enemies could be failed in their attempts towards Esa ﷺ so that no harm comes to him and so that Allah's promise of saving him from their designs could be fulfilled. At such a time Esa ﷺ was informed by revelation: 'O Esa ﷺ, do not fear, your time will be fulfilled. I shall lift you up to the heavens to Me. And I will keep you safe from all enemies. And your followers will at all times be victorious against their enemies. And in the end the return shall be to Me and I will judge between them as to those things wherein they differed.'

The Qur'ān says:

"(And remember that time) when Allah said: "O Esa, I will take you and raise you to Myself and clear you (of the falsehood) of those who blaspheme. I will make those who follow you superior to those who reject faith. To the day of Resurrection. Then shall you all return to Me and I will judge between you of the matters wherein you dispute."
(3:55)

Further:

(On the day of *Qiyaamat* Allah will enumerate to Esa ﷺ all his favours and say to him): "And

remember that time when I restrained Bani Israel from (violence to) you, when you showed them the clear signs And the unbelievers among them said: "This is nothing but evident magic."
(5:113)

So now that Esa ﷺ had been set at ease that in spite of the surrounding of his house the enemy will not be kill him and than an unseen hand was going to raise him up to the heavens, and that he would be saved from his enemies, another question arises as to how that was accomplished. After all the Jews and Christians maintain that Esa ﷺ was crucified on the cross and that he was beaten. In reply the Qur'ān clearly states that the story of his death on the cross is out and out untrue.

What happened was that when the Messiah was lifted up alive upto the heavens and the enemies entered the house, the situation was made confusing and dubious to them. They could not understand where Esa ﷺ had gone.

Qur'ān states:

"(And the Jews were cursed) because they said:
"We killed Christ Jesus, the son of Marry.

But they killed him not, nor crucified him,
But so it was made to appear to them.

And those who differ therein are full of doubts
with no certain knowledge.

But only conjecture to follow,
For of a surely, they killed him not.

Nay Allah raised him up unto Himself and Allah
is exalted in power, wise.
(3:157—158)

The above is the verdict which the Holy Qur'ān gives regarding the Hazrat Esa عليه السلام and Sayyeda Mariam in contrast to the fabricated story which the Jews and Christians give. Now that both versions are in front of the reader, he has the scales of justice in his hands. First take the person of Esa عليه السلام and his mission on call to guidance and thereafter once again look at the person of Jesus as a resolute messenger of Allah, one near to Allah and according to the belief of Christians, the son of God, being dejected, helpless with out any supporters, complaining about God having forsaken him. Look at the two contrasting characters and bear in mind that the belief in the doctrine of Atonement is based mostly on the fact the Messiah came to this world as the Son of God, so that he could be crucified on the cross as a ransom for the sins of the world. But then also best in mind that at the time when the moment arrived for his death to occur it seems as if he had forgotten that fact and at the last moment he cried out: "My God, My God why have you forsaken me?" This means that at that time he uttered his dissatisfaction at being thus killed. Does a person not have the right to watch these two contrasting pictures and fail to see reconciliation between them?

Thus if any searcher after the truth takes note of all the aspects of these happenings, he will without hesitation come to the conclusion that the story as told by the Bible is one of contradictions and that the Story as told by the Qur'ān is the truth based upon truth. History bears witness to the fact that after the Messiah and upto before St. Paul the Christians did not believe in the fabricated story as told by the Jews, but when St. Paul placed the foundations of New Christianity upon the doctrines of Trinity and Atonement, they for the strength and stability of these doctrines, they accepted the fabricated version of these events from the Jews and made it part of their religion.

The Few Tafseer Points

A point that needs to be answered is the question: What is the meaning of the phrase in *Surah 4:157*, — "They killed him not, "but so it was made to appear to them." In other words what was the "doubt" and ambiguity" in which they had fallen. The Qur'ān gives the answer in this **ولكن شبه لهم** verse and the verse in *Al-Imran* and that is that He lifted arm up to the heavens.

In *Surah Al-Imran* it is given in a promise of what He was going to do and "that He was going to raise Him up to Him". And *Surah Nisa* it is said in a way of having fulfilled a promise saying:

"They killed him not and did not crucify him.
Nay, but Allah raised him up unto Him." (4:157)

The story goes thus: When the enemies encircled the house to arrest him and went inside, they did not find him inside. Seeing this they were greatly perplexed and surprised and could not understand what had transpired and in this manner they were filled with "doubt and embiguity."

Thereafter the Qur'ān says that those who differ regarding this matter are "in doubt regarding him, with no certainty of knowledge, but only conjecture to follow. For of a certainty they killed him not." (4:157)

Whatever happened after this has already been told. From that story two things become as clear as daylight: (a) that the Jews were so much in doubt that apart from their conjectures, they had no certain knowledge of what happened, and (b) secondly they did kill somebody and spread the word that they had killed the Messiah.

After the clear announcements of the Qur'ān pertaining to the protection and safety of Hazrat Esa عليه السلام and which has been described above the further details of the above two points are further explained in detail by various sayings of the Sahabah and other historical reports. In this regard only such reports are being mentioned which do not contradict the basic facts as mentioned by the Qur'ān. After all some parts of the Qur'ān serves as a *Tafseer* for other parts. That Qur'ān states that the enemies will not even be able to touch him to do him harm and that he was lifted up alive to the heavens and his coming back to this world will be a sign of the coming of *Qiyamat* and that he will return to the world to complete his given task.

According to the reports from the sahabah Nabi Esa عليه السلام and the disciples were in a house on the evening preceding the *Sabbath* in Jerusalem. As a result of the instigation by the Jews the Governor of Judea from Damascus sent a group of soldiers to arrest him. They surrounded the house. At that time Allah lifted Nabi Esa عليه السلام up from among the disciples up to the heavens. When the soldiers entered the house they found someone who looked like Nabi Esa عليه السلام and arrested him and did all those cruel things to him, which were mentioned before this. According to some reports this person was Judas iscarrot. Some mention him as being Georgins and others take him to be Dawood bin Luza. However these reports are not mentioned in the Qur'ān and neither are they mentioned in authentic *Hadith* and whether they are correct or wrong has no bearing on the basis facts. Readers and researches have the choice of either confining themselves to the non-detail account that Esa عليه السلام was saved from all harm and was lifted up to the heavens, and that to the Jews the matter was made to appear as they thought but they actually were

in doubt and had no certain knowledge. They can either accept these facts because they are proved by the Qur'ān or they may accept those unsubstantiated reports with this understanding that the true meaning of the verses on the subject do not depend upon these details for their true interpretation, but these reports only support these verses.

According to *Surah Al-Imran* and *Surah Al-Nisa* it has been established that regarding Nabi Esa ﷺ the Divine decision was that he should be ascended up to the heavens alive and thus be saved from his enemies. But not only that. The Qur'ān also at various occasions has thrown light through various conclusive texts on his life and has indicated what wisdom lies in his long life and what wisdom is in his being lifted up to the heavens. So that the hearts of the people of *Imān* be made pleased.

Belief in Esa ﷺ before His Death

Qur'ān states:

"There is none of the people of the Book, but must believe in him before his death and on the Day of Judgement he will be a witness against them." | (4:159)

Before this verse the statement was made that they did not kill him, neither did they crucify him, but Allah lifted him up to Himself. This was a rejection of the beliefs of the Jews and the Christians which they had out of their own imagination fixed. They are being told that the claim of killing Nabi Esa ﷺ and the claim to having crucified him are claims which lead to the curse of Allah because false claims and the curse of Allah are two twins following each other. Now in this verse attention is drawn to the fact that if today you boast about this accursed belief, then soon that time will

come along when Nabi Esa عليه السلام, fulfilment of Allah's wisdom on the issue will return to this world and at that time on seeing him every Jew and Christian (*Ahlil Kitaab*) will have no other option but to believe in him. And when on completion of his life-span, he will be taken away from this world he will be a witness against his own people (the Jews and Christians) in the same manner as other Messengers will be witnesses against their peoples.

This is not hidden from anyone that although both the Jews and the Christians are agreed on the story of the crucifixion, yet their beliefs are completely different and based on different bases. The Jews consider Esa عليه السلام as a liar, a fraud and an anti-Christ (*Dajjal*) and thus boast that they killed him on the cross. The Christians on the other hand hold the belief that the first man on earth—Adam was a sinner and all the people on earth are sinners. For this reason Gods attribute of Mercy chose to become a son and sent this son into the world so that in this world he shall be crucified on the cross and be killed so that he can become the atonements for the sins of all in the past and the future and so be the means for them towards salvation.

In the verse in *Surah Al-Nisa* the Qur'ān clearly states that the claim towards the killing of the Messiah, no matter on what belief it is based, it is a cause for the curse of Allah, and a cause for humiliation and loss. To consider that Allah's true Messenger is a liar and a fraud is also a cause for Allah's curse. Furthermore, to look upon Allah's servant and the person born as the son of Mariam as the Son of Allah and the hold the false belief of the doctrine of atonement and to belief in the Messiah being crucified and killed is also falsehood and means having gone astray. And in this regard the correct verdict which is based upon the truth is that which

the Qur'ān has given and which is based upon knowledge and revelation.

The Life of Esa ﷺ

The Qur'ān has in eloquently concise manner given the account of ascent of Esa ﷺ to the heavens, his present state of life and his descent at a later stage which will be one of the signs of *Qiyamat*. The details of these things have been given in authentic *Hadith*. In this regard Imam Bukhari and Imam Muslim have reported from various sources that Abu Hurairah رضي الله عنه reports that Rasulullah ﷺ said:

"I swear by Him in whose Hand my life lies, that time will surely come when Esa ﷺ, the son of Mariam, will descend upon you as a ruler and just one. He will break the cross, kill the swine, (in other words destroy present Christianity) and will lift up the *Jizya* and there will be such abundance of wealth that you will not find anyone to accept it and one prostration to Allah will be worth more than this world and what lies in it." Then Abu Hurairah رضي الله عنه said: And if you want confirmation of the Qur'ān, then read:

And there is none of the people of the Book, but must believe in him before his death. And on the Day of Judgement he will be a witness against them." (4:159) *Bukhari: Kitabul Ambiya*

According to Bukhari and Muslim on the authority of Naafi the slave of Abu Qata'da, Abu Hurairay رضي الله عنه reports that Rasulullah ﷺ said:

"How will be your condition on that day when the son of Mariam will descend upon you. He

will descend upon you when a person from among you will be your Imam." (*Kitabul Ambiya*)

These and numerous other *Ahadith* are found pertaining to the life and return of Hazrat Esa عليه السلام to this world. These *Ahadith* are all *Saheeh* and in *Hadith* terminology are not lower in rank than *Saheeh* or *Hasan* as far as authenticity is concerned and as for these *Ahadith* being well-known (*Mashhoor*), they have been reported by Imam Tirmidhi, Hafiz Iaduddeen bin Katheer, Hafiz Ibn Hajar Asqalani, and various other eminent scholars of *Hadith*. In fact some *Sahabah* report that Rasulullah صلى الله عليه وسلم made these utterances in the presence of numerous *Sahabah* while delivering the *Khutbah* and those *Sahabah* during the era of the four rightly guided *Khalifas* used to recite those *Hadith* in the presence of many others. Among those *Sahabah* whose thousands of students heard these utterances are the following persons of high rank known for their high discipline and strong powers of memory, trustworthiness and great knowledge in which aspects they were considered Imams and leaders: Saeed bin Musayyib رضي الله عنه, Naafi رضي الله عنه, the slave of Qatadah, Hanzala bin Ali al-Aslami رضي الله عنه, Abdur Rahman bin Adam رضي الله عنه, Abu Salmah رضي الله عنه, Abu Oamrah رضي الله عنه, Atan bin Bishaar رضي الله عنه, Abu Suhail رضي الله عنه, Mosul bin Ghaffaara رضي الله عنه, Yahya bin Abi Ammer رضي الله عنه, Jubayr bin Nadeer رضي الله عنه, Urwa bin Masood Thaqafi رضي الله عنه, Abdullah bin Zaid Ansari رضي الله عنه, Abu Zar'a رضي الله عنه, Yakoob bin Aamir Abu Nasrah رضي الله عنه, Abu Tufail رضي الله عنه.

Thereafter among the students of these scholars and scholars of *Hadith* who had heard from them and who were themselves known as the Imams of *Hadith* and the *Ameerul Mumineen* in *Hadith* and became known as such, some of their names are the following: Ibn Shihaab Zuhri رضي الله عنه, Sufyaan

bin Layth ﷺ, Ibn Abi Thee'b ﷺ, Owza'ee ﷺ, Abdur Rahman bin Abu Ammer ﷺ, Suhail ﷺ, Jabalah bin Suhaim ﷺ, Ali bin Zaid ﷺ, Abu Raafi ﷺ, Abdur Rahman bin Jubayr ﷺ, Nu'maan bin Saalim ﷺ, Ma'mar ﷺ, Abdur Rahman bin Ubaidullah ﷺ.

These *Ahadith* had become so well-known and famous during the times of the *Sahabah* and the *Tabi'een* and had become so accepted in scholarly circles that according to the Imams of *Hadith* the question of the life of Esa ﷺ and his return had reached the stage of being '*Mutawwatir*', so much so that they called these *Aadith* '*Mutawaatir*.' And so these *Ahadith* have been accepted throughout the ages. Hence these authentic *Ahadith* have been reported by such great scholars as Imam Ahmad, Imam Bukhari, Imam Muslim, Imam Abu Dawood, Imam Nisai, Imam Tirmidhi and Imam Abu Majah—the authors of the authentic books of *Hadeeth*. And they all are agreed that the reporters of these *Ahadith* are known for their transworthiness. This is the reason why it is said that on the question of the life and the return of Nabi Esa ﷺ the Muslim *Ummat* has reached a general consensus. Therefore in the well-known Book on Islamic doctrines and beliefs *sifarayni* there is a clear in direction that this *Ummat* has reached general consensus on this issue: It states:

"And among the signs of the coming of *Qiyaamat*, the third sign is this that Hazrat Maseeh, Esa bin Mariam ﷺ will descend from the heavens and this descend from the heavens is proven in the *Qur'ān*, the *Sunnat* and the general consensus of the *Ummat*. As for as this general consensus is concerned, there is no doubt whatsoever that Hazrat Esa ﷺ will descend from the heavens and

regarding this fact not one of the followers of the *Shariat* are of a different opinion. However only the philosophers and the religions ones have denied it and in Islam their rejection has no influence on the consensus of the *Ummat*."

The Events at the Descent of Esa ﷺ

The events that will take place at the time of the descent of Nabi Esa عليه السلام according to the authentic *Hadith* is given in proper sequence will be thus:

The day of *Qiyaamat* will be on a fixed day but except for Allah no one knows when it will be. It will dawn very suddenly. Says the Qur'ān:

"Verily the knowledge of the Hour (of *Qiyamat*) is with Allah (alone). (31:34)

And: "Until on a sudden the hour is on them." (6:31)

And further: "All of a Sudden will it come to you." (7:178)

According to the *Hadith-e-Jibrael* Rasulullah ﷺ told Jibrael:

"Regarding the question as to when *Qiyaamat* will be, the one questioned does not know more than the questioner."

According to another *Hadith* one *Sahabi* reports: "I heard Rasulullah ﷺ say one month before he died: "You question me regarding *Qiyaamat*, but verily that knowledge is only with Allah."

However the Qur'ān and certain authentic *Hadith* have given some events that will occur shortly before *Qiyaamat* as a sign of its being near at hand. One of those signs is the descent of Nabi Esa ﷺ from the heavens, the details of which is as follows:

"A fierce battle will be raging between the Muslim and the Christians and the leadership of the Muslims will be in the hands of a man from the off-spring of Rasulullah ﷺ. He will be called the "*Mahdi*". At that time also will appear the messiah of falsehood—Dajjal—(the Anti Christ). This Dajjal will actually be of Jewish off-spring and will be one-eyed. On his forehead there will be the letters *Kaaf, Faa* and *Raa*—*Kafir* and the people of *Imān* will be able to read it with their *Imani* perception. The people of *Imān* will be safe from the treachery and deception. First he will make the claim to be God, and like a cheating juggler with sleight of hand will show some tricks akin to magic and thereby try to pull people's attention towards him. But seeing himself unsuccessful in that he will claim to be the Messiah of guidance. The Jews in large numbers will follow him. This is so because they already rejected the Messiah when he came and claimed to have killed him. Up to today they are still awaiting the coming of the Messiah. And so one day at the *Jamia Masjid* of Damascus the Muslims will be busy gathering for the performing *Salaah* in the dark and while the *Iqamat* will be recited in preparation for the *Salah* with Imam Mahdi to lead prayers and at that moment a noise will be

heard to pull the attention towards it. The Muslims will look up towards the noise coming from the sky and will notice a white cloud above. Soon thereafter they will see Nabi Esa ﷺ descending dressed in two yellow cloths with two angels on his sides. The angels will leave him at the *Minaret* of the *Masjid* and return back to the heavens. From that moment onwards Nabi Esa ﷺ will again become connected to this world. Then he will become once again subject to man's natural needs and in order to descend down to the courtyard of the Mosque he will look for the stairs to come down. Very soon he will descend and enter the lines of those ready for *Salaah*. The *Imam* of the Muslims (Imam Mahdi) will in his honour step backwards so that Esa ﷺ may lead the prayers but he will reply: "This *Iqaamat* has been recited for you to lead prayers. So proceed to lead the *Salaah*."

After the *Salaah* the leadership of the Muslims will be taken over by Hazrat Esa ﷺ. He will then proceed in battle against the anti Christ (Dajjal) and will find him at the gate Babul-Hudd, one of the gates of the town. Dajjal will realise that the time for the end of his treachery and deception had come. Like a metal he will begin to melt and Esa ﷺ will step forward and finish him off. All those Jews who had been following him will then embrace Islam and follow the guidance of the Messiah. Then they will be seen standing with the Muslims shoulder to shoulder. All this will have a definite effect upon the non-Muslims and the polytheists and they too will embrace Islam and so at that time there will be no other *Deen* remained except Islam.

A short while after this Yajooj and Majooj will come out of their hiding place and according to the instructions of Allah Nabi Esa ﷺ will keep the Muslims safe from the evils of these two tribes.

Nabi Esa (*Alaihis Salām*)'s rule on earth will last for forty years and in this period he will spend a married life and during his time the world will be so filled with peace and justice and there will be such goodness and blessings that the goat and the lion will peacefully drink water from the same shore of a river, and at that time evil and iniquity will be overcome.

Note: According to Imam Muslim his rule will last for sixty years.

The Death of Messiah

After ruling for forty year Hazrat Esa ﷺ will die and will be buried at the side of Rasulullah ﷺ. Hazrat Abu Hurairah رضي الله عنه reports in a long *Hadith*: "Then Esa ﷺ will descend to this earth and rule over it for a period of forty years. Thereafter he will die. The Muslims will recite his funeral prayers and they will bury him." (Ibn Majah)

Imam Tirmidhi has quoted the following *Hadith* on the authority of Hasan Muhammad bin Yusuf bin Abdullah bin Salaam from Abdullah bin Salaam رضي الله عنه who said:

"In the Torah the description of Rasulullah ﷺ is given and this is also mentioned that Esa ﷺ will be buried at his side."

Nabi Esa ﷺ and the Day of Qiyaamat

In *Surah Maida* various aspects of the life of Nabi Esa ﷺ has been dealt with and at the end of the *Surah* the

Surah is terminated with mention of him once more. At that moment Allah first of all drew the picture of how the various prophets will be questioned about their peoples. Those prophets will reply in great respect that they did not know. They will reply that Allah had fixed this day of Reckoning so that the reality of all affairs be brought to the fore so that judgement be given in connection with all things. They will reply that they are only judges as to the outward appearance of things while Allah alone is aware of the inner secrets. "So what evidence can we give today. All that we can say is that we know nothing. You are the knower of the Seen and the unseen and you know all things."

Qur'ān says:

"One day Allah will gather the prophets together and ask: "What was the response you received (from men of your teachings)? They will say: "We have no knowledge. It is you who knows in full all that is hidden."

In the next verse Nabi Esa's ~~re~~ reply is given and his reply is in accordance with the reply of the other prophets:

"And behold! Allah will say, O Esa son of Mariam, did you say to men worship me and my mother as gods in derogation of Allah?"

He will say: "Glory to you. Never could I saw what I had no right (to say)

Had I said such a thing, you would indeed have known it.

You know what is in my heart, though I know not what is in yours.

For you know in full all that is hidden.

Never said I to them except what you commanded me to say:

"Worship Allah, My Lord and Your Lord."

And I was a witness unto them while I dwelt among them.

And when you took me up, you were the Watcher over them

And you are witness to all things.

If you are going to punish them, they are your servants.

And if you forgive them, you are the Exalted in Power, the Wise. (5:119—121)

When Nabi Esa ﷺ had given his reply Allah will announce:

"This is a day on which the truthful will profit from their truth

Theirs are gardens with rivers flowing beneath—their eternal home.

Allah, well-pleasure with them and they will Allah.

That is the Great Salvation (the fulfilment of all desires) (5:122)

This reply of Nabi Esa ﷺ to Allah's question is what is expected of an eminent prophet of Allah. He will first put forth the excuse as to how he could have said such a thing which is completely in contrast with truth: "Glory be to you, It is not filling that I should say that which is not true." Then he will express his knowledge as being nothing in comparison with Allah's. "If I had said that, you would have know it. For you know what is in me and I know not what is

in Yours. Verily you are the Knower of the Unseen." Then he will explain what was his duty to convey: "I did not tell them except that which you commanded me to say: Worship Allah, My Lord and Your Lord." Now as to how his people responded to his call, he says:

"And I was a witness over them while I was among them. And when you did take me up, you were the watcher over them. And you are a witness over all things."

And then bearing in mind that among the people there were both true believers as well as rejecters of truth, he expressed the fact that the coming of the punishment and the wish for forgiveness, he says:

"If you punish them, (you have the right to do so) as they are your servants. And if you forgive them, (you have the right) for reply you are the mighty, the Wise One."

Thereupon Allah passed his Judgement according to his law of justice, so that he who deserves mercy and forgiveness not be filled with disappointment, but he happy and overjoyed and so that those deserving of punishment not be expecting what they do not deserve." (5:119)

The above verse clearly indicates that this is what is to take place at the time of *Qiyaamat*, not at the time of Esa (*Alaihis Salām*)'s return to the world.

The Divisions of Bani Israel

In previous pages it has been explained that Allah gave to Nabi Esa ~~the~~ the Injeel. This Revealed Book was actually an appendix and the completion of the Toraat. That means that

although the basis of Nabi Esa (Alaihis Salām)'s teachings were in fact the Toraat, but because of their iniquities and strayings of the Jews, which meant that Allah had to send Nabi Esa ﷺ for rectifying their faults, the Injeel was sent. Although before the advent of Nabi Esa ﷺ, the Jewish beliefs and their practical activities had reached such a state that they were innumerable, Nabi Esa ﷺ took the steps to repair their condition. Among others there were some fundamental faults to which attention had to be given. And in these fields Nabi Esa ﷺ spent much effort:

- (a) Among the Jews was a group who believed that the deeds of a person, good or bad is being punished or rewarded in this life. As for the hereafter and the day of *Qiyaamat*, punishment and reward after death, resurrection—all these beliefs are wrong. These were the Saducees.
- (b) A second group did believe in all those things of the hereafter but they also believed that for reaching to Allah it was necessary that one should avoid worldly pleasures and the secluded from the people of this world and to live an ascetic life. Hence they preformed to live away from societies in monasteries and huts. However this group had before the advent of Nabi Esa ﷺ lost their position and under the ruse of having cut themselves off from the world were being involved with all worldly and dirty things. Outwardly they were still appearing ascetic hermits but in their private lives they were guilty of the most heinous sins, permissiveness and drunkenness. These were the farisees.
- (c) The third group had to do with service to the Holy Temple. Their situation was such that the service which

they were supposed to deliver for the pleasure of God and which was to be based upon sincerity, these services were made into a form of business and for as long as they were not paid for any services they refused to deliver. So much so that they ever went so far as to alter the texts of the Toraat. These were the priests.

- (d) The fourth group were above all these others. They had gradually succeeded in lefting the general public believe that there were no basic principles of religion except those which they issued. They had the prerogative to declare the permissible things as non-permissible and to declare the non-permissible things as permissible. They could add to the religion and discard from it. They had the right to write for someone a pass to enter paradise and for whomsoever they wished they could write out a certificate for entrance to hell. In other words they were among Bani Israel, "the gods other than God almighty." In the alterations of the Toraat both in words and in meaning they had become very advanced. Through all this they had been seeking to acquire worldly wealth, and for the sake of pleasing the public were prepared to change and alter the injunctions of *Deen*. These were the Ahbaar "Rabbis" and the scholars.

These were the various group of people and their beliefs and these were the people among Nabi Esa ~~عليه السلام~~ had to carry on his mission, and for whom rectification he was sent. He first took careful notice of each ones beliefs and with sympathy and love criticised their actions, encouraging them to bring about changes for the better. He endeavoured to remove from them all evils and to connect them once more to the Creator. However, they refused to make alternations to their evil deeds and not only that, they also started calling

him 'the Maseeh of falsehood', becoming his opponents in the spread of the truth. They also made various plans against him and even were bound to seek to kill him.

The Four Versions of the Injeel

If it the unanimous verdict of all scholars even Christians, that the Injeels which was revealed to Nabi Esa ﷺ, is not any one of the Injeels that we have today. What we have today are translations from the Greek and other languages and these versions have undergone various changes, omissions and additions. Further it is not even established that certainly these Books have been written by the students and disciples of Esa ﷺ. There is a strong possibility that they were compiled much later by other writers. However in these Books and their translations there most certainly are certain sermons and utterances of advice give by Nabi Esa ﷺ. Hence occasionally one gets the impression that in parts they contain his actual words.

(Maulana Hifzur Rahman produced an interesting discussion on the present day Injeel and the conclusion of it is that not the original Injeel. Recently another writer Maurice Bicaillie wrote a book: "*The Bible, Science and the Qur'ān*", in which he gave his scholarly research on the topic. Both these discussion are worth reading and studying).

The Qur'ān and the Injeel

It is a basic principal of the Qur'ān that just as Allah is only one, so also His truth is only one. Such truth does not belong to any special nation, people or group. In every nation or country Allah's message of guidance is based on the same basis which has always remained the means of guidance for Allah's true messengers and prophets.

That is what was called, 'The straight path' or 'Islam'. The Qur'ān came to teach this forgotten lesson and to remind mankind of it, and this is the final message which carried within it the truth of previous religions and to accomplish the task of being a guidance for all mankind on earth. As such, to reject this message now is tantamount to reject all the truth of Allah.

In view of this basic principal the Qur'ān has praised the eminent position of Hazrat Esa عليه السلام and has admitted that the Injeel is indeed an inspired Book and that it is revealed from Him, but at the same time also informed that scholars have altered the original teachings and have altered it in various places to change its original texts to include Blospheny and 'Shirk'. At various places the Qur'ān also accuses the *Ahlil Kitaab* of acting against the teachings of the Toraat and the Injeel. This shows that even though the original texts of the Toraat had been already altered at the time the Qur'ān was revealed, those versions of it which was in the world at the time were not fit to be called the Injeel of Esa عليه السلام. Still the Qur'ān mentions both these books with respect:

Says the Qur'ān: "O Muhammad ﷺ, It is He who sent down to you (step by step) in truth the Book confirming what went before it.

And He sent down the Toraat (of Musa عليه السلام) and the Injeel (of Jesus) before this as a guide to mankind and He sent down the Criterion (to judge between right and wrong). (3:3—4)

Further:

"And Allah will teach him the Book and Wisdom, the Toraat and the Injeel." (3:48)

And:

"O People of the Book why do you dispute about Ibraheem when the Toraat and the Injeel were not revealed till after him? Have you no understanding." (3:65)

And:

"And in their footsteps We sent Esa, the son of Mariam, confirming the Toraat which had come before him, And we sent him the Injeel, there in was guidance and light and confirmation of the law that had come before him a guidance and an admonition to those who fear Allah.

"Let the people of the Injeel judge by what Allah had revealed therein If any do fail to judge by (the light of) what Allah had revealed, they are (no better than) these who rebel." (5:49—50)

And:

"And if only they had stood fast by the Toraat and the Injeel. And all the revelations that was sent to them from their Lord, they would have enjoyed happiness and sustenance from above them and from beneath their feet under them;

There is firm among them a party on the right course

By many of them follow a course that is evil." (5:69)

Further:

"Say (O Muhammad ﷺ): O People of the Book, you have no ground to stand upon unless you

stand fast on the Toraat, the Injeel and all the revelations which had come to you from your Lord." (5:71)

Further:

.... "And behold, O Esa ﷺ I taught you the Book and wisdom the Toraah and the Injeel." (5:113)

Qur'ān also says:

("The righteous ones are) Those who follow the Messenger, the unlettered prophet whom they find mentioned in their scriptures in the Toraat and the injeel. (7:157)

Also:

"Allah had purchased from the believers their persons and their goods for theirs (in return) is the Garden (of paradise).

They fight in His cause and slay and are slain—

A promise binding on Him in truth through the Toraat, the Injeel and the Qur'ān." (9:11)

All these praises are for that Toraat and Injeel which was fit to be called the Mosaic Toraat and the Injeel of Esa ﷺ—the real Books of Allah, but what have the Jews and Christians done to these books. The Qur'ān tells the story in its own words:

Says the Qur'ān:

"Can you (O men of Faith) entertain the hope that they will believe in you, seeing that a party of them heard the word of Allah and perverted it knowingly after they understood it?" (2:75)

And:

"And woe to those who write the Book with their own hands and then say, "This is from God"—to traffic with it for a miserable price!

Woe to them for what their hands do write and for the gain they make thereby." (2:79)

"They (the People of the Book) change the words from their right places." (5:14)

And further for a very meagre price they used the verses of Allah as is explained in *Surah Baqarah*, *Surah al-Imran*, *Surah Nisaa* and *Surah Tobah* in various verses of the Qur'ān. In other words the Jews and Christians were guilty of various forms of alternations in the texts both word-for-word alteration as well as changes in meaning and interpretations. Very after this was done with the purpose of acquiring worldly gain. There can hardly be a more unfortunate deed than this which earns the curses of Allah.

The Qur'ān and the Doctrine of Trinity

At the time of Revelation of the Qur'ān there were three major groups into which the Christians were divided according to their beliefs in the Trinity. One group used to say that Jesus the Messiah was God himself who came down to this world in the form of the Messiah. A second group used to believe that the Messiah, Esa bin Mariam was the Son of God. The third group used to say that the Oneness of God was in the secret of the Trinity which consisted of God, Jesus and Mariam. This group consisted of two divisions. One group of the two took the Holy Ghost instead of Mariam. In any case they both took Jesus to be one of the Trinity.

The Qur'ān addressed all these groups individually and jointly and with clear arguments explained that in this regard

the correct belief is one and one only viz. That the Messiah was born of the mother Mariam. He was a true Messenger of Allah. Whatever else is said about his divinity the trinity or son ship of God are all false and untrue, irrespective of whether it brings about a lessening of his status as in the case of the Jewish belief that he was a sorrier, magician or a fraud, or whether it brings about an exaggerated status as in the case of the Christians who consider him God or the Son of God or part of the Trinity.

Not only did the Qur'ān proceed to reject the Christian views regarding Jesus but also explained the correct status of the Messiah. And how near he is to Allah so that the views of the Jews the may be rejected.

Nabi Esa ﷺ is a Chosen One

The Qur'ān states:

"Esa ﷺ said: "I am indeed a servant of Allah. He has given me revelation and made me a prophet

And He has made me blessed wheresoever I be and has enjoined on me prayer and charity as long as I live.

He has made me kind to my mother and not overbearing and miserable

So peace is on me the day I was born, the day I day And the day I shall be raised up to life."

(19:30—32)

And:

"He (Esa ﷺ) was no more than a servant. We granted our favour to him And we made him an

example to the Children of Israel. And if it were Our will, we could make angels from among you succeeding each other on the earth."

(43:59—60)

Further:

And remember Esa ﷺ the Son of Mariam said: "O Children of Isarael! I am the Messenger of Allah sent unto you confirming the Toraat which came before me and giving glad tidings of an Apostle to come after me whose name shall be Ahmad."

(61:6)

The Messiah is neither God nor the Son of God

Qur'ān states:

"In blasphemy indeed are those who say that God is the Messiah, the Son of Mariam. Say: Who then has the least power against God if His will were to destroy Christ, the son of Mariam, his mother and all-everyone that is on earth?

For to Allah belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth and all that is between. He creates what He pleases. For Allah has power over all things."

(5:19)

Further:

"They do blasphem. Who say: 'God is Christ the Son of Mariam'.

But Christ said: "O Children of Israel. Worship Allah my Lord and Your Lord."

Whoever joins other Gods with Allah, Allah will forbid him entrance unto the Garden and the

fire will be his abode. There will for the wrong-doers be no one to help." (5:75)

And:

"They say: God has begotten a son. Glory be Him. Nay. To Him belongs all that is in the heavens and on earth. Every thing renders worship unto Him. (2:116)

And:

"The similitude of Esa ﷺ before Allah is as that of Adam ﷺ. He created him from dust. Then said to him: Be! And it was. (3:59)

And:

"O People of the Book commit no excesses in your religion

Nor say of God aught but the truth:

Esa ﷺ the Son of Mariam (no more than) an Apostle of Allah And His word, which He bestowed on Mariam and a spirit proceeding from Him. So believe in Allah and His Messengers say not: "Trinity, desist, it will be better for you

For Allah is One God. Glory by to Him.

For is he exalted above having a son. To Him belong all that is in the heavens and the earth. And enough is Allah as *Wakeel*. (4:171)

Further:

"To Him is due the primal original of the heavens and the earth. How can he have a son when he

has no consort. He created all things and He has full knowledge of all things.

And:

"Christ the Son of Mariam was no more than a Messenger Many were the Messengers who passed away before him. His mother was a woman of truth. They had both to eat their (daily) food. See how Allah makes clear His signs to them." (5:78)

And:

"Christ does not disdain to serve and worship Allah

Nor do the Angels, those nearest to Allah.

Those who disdain His worship and are arrogant He will gather them all together unto Himself to Answer. (4:172)

And:

"The Jews call Uzair the Son of God and the Christians call Esa ﷺ the Son of God. That is a saying from their mouths

In this they but imitate what the unbelievers of old used to say.

Allah's cause be on them: How they are deluded Away from the truth." (9:30)

And:

"Say (O Muhammad ﷺ) He Allah is One, the One and Only. Allah is Eternal, Absolute

He begets not nor is He begotten.

And there is none like unto Him." (112:1—4)

The Qur'ān has with various arguments for the sake of rectifying peoples beliefs given the true beliefs it expects from man. However it is note worthy that in spite of various alternations to the texts of Toraat and Injeel in their present text, still there is not one place in these texts which gives the basis for the doctrine of Trinity. Hence even in the present text of the scriptures there is no proof for this doctrine. For this reason we can say without any doubt that this doctrine of trinity is the result of the temperament created by idol-worship and having been mixed up the idolatry.

Atonement

The second doctrine of Christianity which has destroyed the type face of the Religion is the doctrine of Atonement. The basis of this belief is this that all human beings, good or bad, even the Messengers of Allah are born in sin and are sinners. Thereafter the Mercy of Allah came to the fore and the desire of Allah was that His son should be sent into the world to be crucified to become the ransom for the sins of all mankind and thus provide the Salvation for man.

However, in order to make this belief a solid base, a few very important requirements are necessary without which this belief will not be acceptable. Hence the Christians first of all adopted the belief of the Jews that Jesus was hung on the cross and killed there. Then they, having given acceptance to that belief, they took the next step that in spite of having ascribed Divinity to Christ, the spread the word that the Messiah was not killed for his own sake but for the salvation

of all humanity. And when that happening took place he again put on the cloak of divinity and in the celestial world resumed the relationship between father and son. Now comes the question: What is the result of a religion where instead of correctness of beliefs the criterion for salvation is made the doctrine of Movement? He has at various places made it quite clear that for the salvation of mankind correctness of beliefs, in other words, correct worship of God and good deeds are the only criteria. Whosoever casts aside these two things has strayed from the right path and has been deprived of the correct religion. Says the Qur'ān:

"Verily those who believe (in the Qur'ān) and those who follow the Jewish (Scriptures) and the Christians and the Sabians, any one who believe in Allah and the last day and work righteousness shall have their reward with their Lord. On them shall be no fear Nor shall they grieve."
(2:62)

This means that the object of the Qur'ān's mission of rectification of conditions is not to create a new group like the Christian, Jews and *Sabians* who will be called the '*Mumineen*' as if this is a new national group, that no matter how wrong its beliefs may be, they will at all times be destined to enter paradise. This is not the aim and object of the Qur'ān. It in fact makes the announcement that no matter to what group one belongs and as long as he worships Allah in accordance with the instructions of the Qur'ān and performs righteous deeds, he will attain salvation and be successful. Otherwise even if he was born in the house of a Muslim and in that society came to his death, but lived a live without worship of Allah and without righteous deeds there will be no success for him. In this way the Qur'ān

destroyed the very basis on which the doctrine of Alonement was laid.

Something worth paying attention to:

There is something that should never be forgotten. That is that the interpreters of previous religions, the *Mufasssireen* and the translators of scriptural texts in their acts of altering those texts and interpolating them found much help in interpreting those texts by making use of metaphors, figurative expressions and similes instead of explaining the basic beliefs in clear unambiguous terms. The result of all this was that when the real worshippers and philosophers entered into this originally true religion, and accepted it as their religion for life, they brought their philosophic ideas and their idolatious tendencies with them and made those metaphors, figurate expressions and similes the basis for the understanding of the doctrines and in this way altered the reality of the religion, making it into a strange mixture of truth and polytheistic ideas. This is the reason why the Qur'ān in explaining the existence of Allah, His Oneness, the Holy Books, the Angels of Allah and the fundamental principles of the *Deen*, has used such words and expressions which are clear and unambiguous, leaving out all metaphors, figurate expressions and similes. This was done so that no irreligious one or polytheistic idolator could not find a means towards spreading his un-Islamic ideas. And should, in spite of that any person should be bold enough to try anything like that the Qur'ān itself will in clear terms reject such interpretations.

Note: There are many topics concerning Hazrat Esa عليه السلام and Hazrat Mariam as regards the birth of Nabi Esa عليه السلام, his life, his miracles etc. And in this regard many booklet and articles have been written. Maulana Seoharwy has on all

these topics given quite detailed discussions. However this abridged version of his book could not contain all those details and we have only touched on them in brief. Readers who have the desire to delve into greater detail may return to the original book.

QASASUL AMBIYAA

STORIES OF THE PROPHETS

Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy (Rah.)



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Qasasul Ambiyaa

(Stories of the Prophets)

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Qasasul Ambiyaa

The Holy Qur'ān does not relate historical facts merely for the sake of telling a story which is of historical value. Its main aim in relating happenings is to draw attention to the results, conclusions and deductions from these incidents so that they become a source of guidance for men and prove to be lessons for them that appeal to their minds and emotions that from these historical events, lessons should be derived. These lessons should convince them that the existence of Allah is an undeniable fact and that His Mighty Hand is playing a major role in the affairs of men. It should also bring to their notice that to follow the stipulations of His deen brings success and leads to salvation and is the way towards all progress. That is what Islām—the natural religion—is about.

From: Qasasul Qur'ān

Preface

The most authentic and comprehensive work of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy, *Qasasul Qur'ān* needs no introduction. However, the Manner in which our friend Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version of a voluminous and bulky work he has undoubtedly, fulfilled one of the needs of this time. He has adopted such a method of abridgement whereby not only has he retained and mentioned every important fact in the lives of the Holy Prophets (*Alaihimus Salām*) and other saintly personalities, which are of lessons to men, but also discussed in brought outline some other important matters. It is hoped that with Allah's grace, those persons who are occupied and busy at all times, will be able to derive adequate benefit from this work.

The great effort of Sayed Tanzeem Hussain in this old age of his is really something praiseworthy. May Allah reward him well for this great effort.

Qari Sayed Rasheedul-Hasan Hussainy Nadwi

Imam and Khateeb

Jama Masjid, New Town

Allamah Binori Town, Karachi

P5 Muharram, 1308 Hijri

Publisher's Foreword

The respected personality of Maulana Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy is one of the most eminent Ulama of the Indo-Pak Sub-Continent. His most approved and well-known book, *Qasasul-Qur'ān* is considered to be a unique publication on this subject. The point that distinguishes it from other similar books is the fact that after every story, Maulana has made use of deep thought and reflection to present to the readers the lessons and points of guidance from the related episodes. Thus for the teachers and lecturers at *Deeni Madressas* and for preachers in mosques and students of deen the study and perusal of this book is of utmost benefit.

The original book appeared in four volumes with over 1800 pages of subject matter. Sayed Tanzeem Hussain Saheb has brought forth an abridged version there of in only 600 pages and this has been met with a verdict of approval from all academic circles, especially by virtue of the fact that he has fulfilled one of the most pressing needs of the time and by leaving aside unimportant discussions have given the busy and occupied ones also a chance to benefit from these work. May Allah reward him well.

Author's Foreword

All praise be to Allah who has guided us with the Holy Book and revealed to us the Qur'ān in a clear Arabic language and in it. He related the best of stories as an admonition and a reminder for the believers. And May peace and blessings be upon the Most truthful and trustworthy Prophet Muhammad ﷺ, the messenger of Allah and seal of all the Prophets and upon his offspring, and companions who were all of them guiding stars for all the righteous ones.

Among the inimitable ways in which Allah has chosen for the sake of the guidance of men, is this that attention is drawn to the good and bad deeds of nations and the resultant fruits of such deeds of which they are reminded so that those deeds may be a lesson for men. For this reason those stories are not being related in a style as is generally done in history. The major aim is to convey the truth and to invite to Allah and with this in mind attention is only drawn to those aspects which furthers this objective. For this reason there is constant repetition so that these events can sink into the hearts and minds of listeners and they become attentive towards them. This sinking in and attentiveness can only be achieved if the same event is repeated in various ways and styles whereby sleeping faculties are woken up.

The Qur'ānic stories and events deal mostly with previous nations and the Messengers of Allah (*Alaihimus*

Salām) who were sent to them and bit by bit other matters also become included there-in, mostly dealing with the arguments over good and bad and the battles between the friends of Allah and the friends of *Shaitan*, which in itself proves to be a great lesson and admonishment for me.

But, leaving others aside, there are today so few Muslims who derive benefit from Allah's last and perfect law-book, the Qur'ān, to fill our hearts with *Iman* and *Yaqeen*. After all it is Allah's law and we are commanded to implement its orders in our lives, Moreover we are required to ponder over its meanings as this Qur'ān is the means forwards acquiring success and salvation in both this world and the here after.

At the time of the Revelation of the Qur'ān, the Messenger of Allah became so distressed and defected at the enmity and opposition of the polytheists that he raised this complaint to Allah:

(5:25—30)

However, in this 15th century, if we should examine our hearts, we will find that in spite of our claims to be Muslims and believing the Qur'ān to be the word of Allah, how few are who have made this word of Allah the pattern for their lives and the model on which to base their lives, who read and recited with this aim in mind?

It was my aim, seeing this condition of my people and myself, to translate this great source of admonition into Urdu so that by presenting the translated version, the hearts of people will automatically become drawn to the original i.e., the Qur'ān and thereby acquire everlasting happiness.

In spite of my simple style of writing, care has been taken to confine myself to a few special points.

- (a) In this book the basis for all the stories is the Holy Qur'ān and the authentic *Hadith* and these have been further elucidated with historical facts.
- (b) Where there appears any contradiction or differences in the stories as told in the old testament and the Qur'ān, then with clear arguments an effort has been made either to reconcile the versions or with clear arguments to prove the truth as is expounded in the Qur'ān.
- (c) An effort has been made to point out the nonsensical Israili stories and where there have been nonsensical objections from enemies, these have in the light of the true facts been made clear for what they are.
- (d) In some special places there have been introduced some discussions on matters of disputes in *Tafseer* and *Hadith* and after discussing these the views of the saintly elders have been mentioned as a solution.
- (e) The facts concerning every Prophet ﷺ and in which chapter of the Qur'ān they are mentioned, has been gathered in one place.
- (f) Lastly, together with all the above points, a special heading of "Results and lessons", is introduced, giving the actual objective of this book and its main purpose viz., admonition and warning. Special attention is drawn to this aspect.

Servant of the Millat

Muhammad Hifzur Rahman Seoharwy

22 Rajab, 1360 Hijri

Translator's Foreword

For me as the translator of this book by Maulana Hifzur Rahman is a great honour. Throughout my student days in Darul Uloom Deoband in India, Maulana Hifzur Rahman or as we know him then as the *Mujahid-e-Millat* was one of the most respected leaders of the Muslim community. We used to flock to listen to his most interesting lectures. And as the general secretary of the *Jamiatul-Ulama*, and a M.P. he was also a great 'Alim (scholar) as can be gauged from this book *Qasasul Ambiya* (Tales of the Prophets) which entailed great research. I can remember whenever the students were confronted with any problem in the lives of any of the prophets, they always took refuge in Maulana's book for answers. I took upon it as a great honour in being in some small manner associated with Maulana's scholarship, even though this is an abridged version of the original book. But I must also state that I found great difficulty in translating this book because of the exceptionally high quality of the Urdu language used in the book.

I hope that the English translation of Maulana Hifzur Rahman's scholarly work will also be of great benefit to the English-speaking people. I just hope that I have been able to do justice to the original thoughts of the author.

Yusuf Karaan
Strand, South Africa